Chapter Forty-Eight

The Seventh Crusade

Between 1244 and 1250, Egypt changes hands, and another crusade fails

DECEMBER IN PARIS, 1244: nearly Christmas. Louis IX of France lay ill, so close to death that he could neither speak nor move. Even the movement of his breath had ceased. “He was in such evil case,” his friend and biographer Jean de Joinville writes, “that, as they tell, one of the ladies who tended him wished to draw the sheet over his face, and said that he was dead.”[1]

Thirty years old, Louis IX—crowned king at twelve, governed by his mother until he turned twenty—had just finished beating back Henry III’s unsuccessful invasion of the western French lands. He was at the height of his strength, but he had no male heirs; his death would throw France into crisis. The entire palace wept. The doctors left; the doors to his room were flung open for mourners; priests arrived to “commend his soul.” And then, suddenly, the king took a deep breath and sighed.[2]

He had emerged from his coma; and when he had recovered enough to sit up and speak, he announced that in thanksgiving, he would go on crusade.

This announcement was greeted with joy by everyone except his mother Blanche, who tried to talk him out of it and even offered to pay for mercenaries who could go in his place. But Louis was unmoved. He had made a sacred vow, and he was not Frederick II; he would not renege.[3]

Even before his illness, Louis IX had probably been contemplating